

Regular Meeting
December 18, 2017
School Committee Meeting
Council Chambers

The regular meeting of the Medford School Committee was called to order by Mayor Burke in the City Hall Council Chambers at 7:05 p.m. Those present were Ms. Cugno, Ms. DiBenedetto, Ms. Kreatz, Ms. Mustone, Mr. Skerry, Ms. Van der Kloot, Mayor Burke and Superintendent Belson. Medford High School student representative Justin Tseng was also present.

Tony Szykniej and the Medford High School Orchestra played a selection of holiday music.

School Committee members thanked Mr. Szykniej, the students and the parents for their continued support.

Mayor Burke invited Vice Chair Cugno to preside over the meeting.

On the motion of Mr. Skerry seconded by Ms. Kreatz that the minutes of December 4, 2017 be approved:

Vote:

Yes: 7
No: 0
Absent: 0

On the motion of Mr. Skerry seconded by Ms. Van der Kloot that the Bills/Transfer of Funds be approved:

Voted: That the Bills/Transfer of Funds be approved.

Roll Call:

Yea: 7 Cugno, DiBenedetto, Kreatz, Mustone, Skerry, Van der Kloot, Burke
Nay: 0
Absent: 0

On the motion of Mr. Skerry seconded by Ms. DiBenedetto that the Payrolls be approved:

Voted: That the Payrolls be approved

Roll Call:

Yea: 7 Cugno, DiBenedetto, Kreatz, Mustone, Skerry, Van der Kloot, Burke
Nay: 0
Absent: 0

Committee of the Whole Meeting Minutes – December 11, 2017

Secretary Paulette Van der Kloot provided a brief overview of the meeting.

On the motion of Mr. Skerry seconded by Mayor Burke the report was accepted and placed on file.

Vote:

Yes: 7
No: 0
Absent: 0

Community Participation

Community member Maureen Ronyne was given permission to speak. She said that her concern is with the math scores at the Columbus School. Superintendent Belson read an update memo which stated the following: as part of our plan to assist the students at the Columbus with their math preparation students in grades 3, 4 and 5 who require extra assistance to master the math curriculum will be eligible to receive additional tutoring from paid MPS teachers. Students will receive between one and two hours per week based upon need. We will arrange with Eastern Bus for an afterschool bus for these students. There are multiple logistics to be worked out and there may need to be modifications. We will make adjustments based upon multiple factors. We will keep the School Committee informed as we progress with implementation.

Discussion:

Ms. DiBenedetto asked what the criteria is for students to be tutored. Superintendent Belson answered that it will be determined by the principals and teachers. He also commented that you cannot make them participate. Ms. DiBenedetto asked if parents can request the tutoring. Superintendent Belson replied that they will have to wait and see what the response is and if we have six teachers to tutor.

On the motion of Ms. DiBenetto seconded by Mr. Skerry to approve the program with an update report due at the next meeting:

Roll Call:

Yea: 7 Cugno, DiBenedetto, Kreatz, Mustone, Skerry, Van der Kloot, Burke
Nay: 0
Absent: 0

Recommendation to Accept Gift to Robotics Club

Director of Mathematics Carolyn Joy presented the report. Ms. Joy stated that Dr. Marthinus Van Schoor, founder and CEO of Midé Technology in Medford has generously offered a gift of \$2,300 to the Medford High School Robotics Team. This gift provides the robotics team the necessary funds for application to the 2018 New England Regional Botball Tournament. This is the seventh year that Dr. Van Schoor and Midé Technology have supported Medford's participation in the competition. The Botball Robotics Team is open to students at Medford High School and Medford Vocational/Technical High School under the advisorship of high school mathematics teacher, Ms. Faiza Khan. We would like to thank Midé Technology for supporting Medford's upcoming generation of programmers and engineers. Ms. Joy introduced Advisor Faiza Khan.

On the motion of Mayor Burke seconded by Ms. Van der Kloot to accept the gift from Dr. Van Schoor:

Roll Call Vote:

Yea: 7 Cugno, DiBenedetto, Kreatz, Mustone, Skerry, Van der Kloot, Burke

Nay: 0

Absent: 0

Mr. Skerry would like to invite Dr. Van Schoor to a future meeting. Ms. DiBenedetto requested a letter of thanks be sent.

Report on Center for Citizenship and Social Responsibility

Director Rich Trotta presented the report. He stated that the mission of the CCSR is to develop responsible global citizens who will be positive contributors to society and will work to combat important social issues such as global warming, addiction, prejudice, racism, pollution, gender bias, poverty, public education, health care, etc. We believe by providing the proper learning activities, we can prevent students from becoming addicted to harmful substances and developing negative perceptions of others. The Center is working with school administration to develop a system-wide initiative to integrate social-emotional learning, citizenship, resiliency and social intelligence into the district curriculum and activities. The following goals support this mission.

Students will:

- act with integrity, respect, and responsibility
- collaborate in diverse groups to address important social issues (listed above)
- understand other people and their circumstance regardless of race, gender, religion, ethnicity, country and culture
- be self-aware, develop self-confidence, to control impulsive behavior and prevent addiction and to provide leadership in community service for the people of Medford and the school district

Update for 2017-2018

Awarded nine mini-grants to faculty and staff to organize and support student projects in district schools. Five faculty members were selected to serve as advisors for student leaders at the Brooks, Columbus, Roberts, McGlynn Middle and the high school. The mini-grants and school based leaders programs are in progress and their student projects will be presented to the school committee when completed next spring. The Medford High School student leaders are working on thirty three outstanding projects. The CCSR plans to:

- provide professional development workshops to faculty and staff in the areas of Project Based Learning (PBL) and strategies for teaching Social-Emotional Learning (SEL) in the classroom
- work with local agencies, provide parents with information and resources on social issues such as addiction, bullying, gender bias, anxiety, depression, etc.
- create a professional library of instructional materials for faculty and staff in the area PBL and SEL
- explore new strategies using the mirror neuron to teach SEL and empathy
- develop field experiences for students to enhance SEL learning outcomes
- utilize technology and the Internet to support instruction
- share our mission and activities with other school districts to encourage the development of more programs that are similar to the CCSR

Mr. Trotta introduced advisor Michael Skorker. Mr. Skorker presented the students who have worked on projects. Each gave an overview of their project.

Discussion:

Mr. Skerry commented that he is excited about the Fells project. It will bring back the area. He suggested contacting the Johnny Appleseed Museum for an apple tree. Ms. DiBenedetto would like to see more about this project in the Transcript. Mr. Skorker said that they have a Facebook page available. Ms. Van der Kloot said these are such positive projects. You are making a difference in Medford. Mayor Burke said that they all show so much passion and it is nice to see such a mix of students working together. It is a great investment. Student Representative Justin Tseng commented that CCSR makes Medford unique. Medford students want to give back. They have a passion doing their projects. He thanked everyone for their hard work.

On the motion of Ms. DiBenedetto seconded by Mr. Skerry the report was accepted and placed on file.

Vote:

Yes: 7
No: 0
Absent: 0

Report on Statement of Interest Application to MSBA

Superintendent Belson reported that The Medford Public Schools submitted a Statement of Interest (SOI) to the Massachusetts School Building Authority (MSBA) last spring. The focus of the SOI was on the upgrade of facilities and systems at Medford High School and Medford Vocational High School. The submission was approved by both the Medford School Committee and the Medford City Council. The MSBA originally received 83 entries from school systems across the state. The state then reduced the pool to 44 proposals. Then reduced it further. Medford was prioritized. This resulted in an onsite visit by a senior staff study visit this past October. The visit went well and the feedback on our project was very good. Last year the MSBA funded 26 projects. This year MSBA will only be able to fund 15 projects. Each year sales tax revenue informs the MSBA of an annual funding cap governing their ability to obligate projects. The allowable limit may rise or fall in any given year. While the notification letter received by the City/District is very direct, discussions with MSBA tells us that we were very close to being funded. We have been encouraged to re-submit for the next fiscal year. It is our intent to do so with the approval of the School Committee and the City Council. The new closing date for submission is April 13, 2018. We will bring this matter up to the School Committee in January 2018 for your consideration.

On the motion of Mr. Skerry seconded Mayor Burke by the report was accepted and placed on file.

Vote:

Yes: 7
No: 0
Absent: 0

Report on Security Cameras

Superintendent Belson stated that this year we will spend approximately \$200,000 on security camera upgrades and replacements at our schools. Security cameras, especially external ones, are very fragile devices. Over the years they have been susceptible to adverse weather conditions and unpredictable power outages. Newer models are more resilient but are not invulnerable. Placement of external cameras on metal poles outside of buildings are more vulnerable to lightning strikes. New camera installation will avoid most of such placements. We have contracted with American Alarm to upgrade and replace various cameras districtwide. We have 154 cameras across the district in our nine schools. At this time we believe that we have sufficient coverage at all of our schools to provide our security. Since some security measures must be kept confidential, this cover page report will not provide details on our cameras. School Committee members are receiving detailed school reports on cameras. The maintenance of full security camera coverage will require that we annually budget significant funding. It may be prudent to set aside funding in a special account to ensure that it will be used each year for upgrades and replacement as well as other security equipment. If not used, then the funding could be rolled over to a subsequent year. Security cameras are only one element of our overall school security and safety response system. We continue to interact with our public safety agencies and to practice special situation drills at all of our schools.

Discussion:

Ms. DiBenedetto asked how locking of the doors is handled at each school. Superintendent Belson replied that he will provide an update.

On the motion of Ms. DiBenedetto to have the update report by mid January
Vote:

Yes: 7
No: 0
Absent: 0

Superintendent Belson replied that he will set up a meeting to discuss.

On the motion of Ms. DiBenedetto to set up a Committee of the Whole meeting to discuss security cameras and door policy:
Vote:

Yes: 7
No: 0
Absent: 0

On the motion of Mayor Burke seconded by Ms. DiBenedetto the report was accepted and placed on file.
Vote:

Yes: 7
No: 0
Absent: 0

Recommendation to Approve School Lunch Charge Policy

Director of Administration and Finance Kirsteen Patterson presented the report. She stated that the Medford Public Schools are on schedule to receive the required DESE state audit review in February. Reviewing documentation in preparation for the audit we identified that Medford does not have an updated School Meal Charge Policy. We are providing a first draft as a starting point for further discussion and comment for approval at another meeting date. Compliance requirements direct the need for a meal charge policy for implementing and enforcing throughout the school year. The purpose is not punitive but rather informative for families to understand the meal program and necessity to maintain a positive balance in student accounts for self-sufficiency for the program. Medford has a relatively low negative balance in relation to its size and enrollment.

Discussion:

Ms. Van der Kloot does not want to single students out with the alternative lunch. She thinks that three days in a row is a short time. Ms. Patterson answered that some districts don't allow any days. Ms. Van der Kloot is concerned with the student who hasn't signed up for free/reduced lunch. Ms. DiBenedetto said that it could be a signal to others if student has a different lunch. It is an issue with her. She referenced information discussed on December 4th and would like answers. Ms. Patterson said this is mandatory for the review/audit. Ms. Mustone questioned when this takes place. Ms. Patterson said not when the student is in line but before they get to the cafeteria. Ms. Van der Kloot stated that the threshold is not the problem but the problem is the different meal.

On the motion of Ms. DiBenedetto to check the wording in document to meet the federal requirements and to bring back to school committee with changes about the meal option for students.

Vote:

Yes: 7
No: 0
Absent: 0

On the motion of Mayor Burke to suspend the rules:

Vote:

Yes: 7
No: 0
Absent: 0

Medford High School Headmaster John Perella presented two updates to the committee. The first report was a follow-up and information regarding the incident with the North Medford bus on Friday December 15. He reported that the bus has not been filled beyond capacity over the past two months. The pick up location has been moved from the executive loop to the MBTA bus loop on the west courtyard. For the remainder of the school year administrators will be reviewing student usage of this bus. All students who are registered to take the bus will be meeting with administration and the Medford Police

on Dec. 19th regarding safety concerns. The central office will be working with Eastern Bus to find secondary buses to assist if/when necessary.

Discussion:

Ms. DiBenedetto asked Dr. Perella to describe the incident. Dr. Perella said that about 30-40 students were in front of the Superintendent's office. It was cold outside that day. As the bus came around the corner the students began pushing and shoving. One student was pushed too far into the street and the bus ran over his foot. The nurse was called immediately. All families were notified and are cooperating with the police.

Ms. DiBenedetto said that she is concerned with the overcrowding of this bus and the way it is monitored. Dr. Perella said that the bus stop has been changed and they are monitoring it along with the other buses. Ms. DiBenedetto requested another update in a month regarding the bus situation. Ms. Kreatz said that she spoke with parents and they mentioned that there is pushing and shoving everyday. Many days there are students sitting on the floor. Superintendent Belson said that they are pushing to get to the back of the bus which is preferred seating. Students will be told about bus behavior. Ms. Kreatz asked if students will be checked getting on the bus. Dr. Perella answered yes, they will be monitored.

Report on Vaping and Juuling

Dr. Perella reported that In response to your request, the following is the manner and strategy Medford High School is dealing with student vaping and juuling. During the end of the 2017 summer, the leadership team became aware of the growing concern regarding the use and abuse of vaping and juuling by students. Since September, we have held numerous faculty and unit meetings to introduce, and communicate the issues regarding this phenomenon. Including:

- Multiple faculty meetings with viewing of informational videos and demonstration of vaping and juuling devices
- CBJ and Building Leadership Team meetings with the Assistant District Attorney, Medford Police Department
- Re-design of health classes to focus on, and distinguish, vaping/juuling from typical tobacco and drug use
- The development of public service announcements by students for students to teach and communicate:
 - What is vaping, myths of vaping, reasons for concerns, behaviors associated with vaping
 - Adolescent brain development and risk for addiction, medical concerns and health complications associated with vaping, big business marketing strategies
- We will be holding a Parent Forum scheduled for *Thursday, Feb 8, 2018 6:30pm* that will include the following:
 - Speakers: Maureen Buzby, Regional Tobacco Prevention Coordinator / Alan Woolf, MD Boston Children's Hospital and School Physician for Melrose Public Schools / Medford Police Department representation
 - "*In Plain Sight*" viewing room for parents following the presentation. Display of ways adolescents can hide drug paraphernalia in their bedrooms.

- Students will be advised through the Assistant Principals, that vaping is not only dangerous but will subject them to school discipline consistent with the student handbook and MIAA sport eligibility. This may include social probation, suspension, and/or referral to law enforcement.

Discussion:

Much discussion was held by school committee members regarding vaping. Ms. Kreatz said that parents are concerned that students are vaping in the halls and in class. She asked if there is a planned student assembly regarding this. Dr. Perella answered that they are working with the health classes to provide information to students.

On the motion to revert back to regular order of business.

School Committee members spoke about their colleagues, Ann Marie Cugno and Robert Skerry. Gifts were presented to the outgoing members.

On the motion of Cugno seconded by Ms. Mustone the meeting was adjourned at 10:00 p.m.

Roll Call:

Yea: 7 Cugno, DiBenedetto, Kreatz, Mustone, Skerry, Van der Kloot, Burke
Nay: 0
Absent: 0

Respectfully submitted:

Paulette Van der Kloot
Secretary

